

neighbours PAKISTAN

■ By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi

She has been called many things recently. "Arrogant", "delusional", "the queen of corruption" and "a kleptocrat in a Hermes scarf" are just some of the epithets her detractors—and there are many—have hurled her way. For her die-hard supporters, however, she is "the saviour of democracy", "the hope of the downtrodden" and "a leader with her finger on the pulse of the country". Whichever view one ascribes to, there is no denying that Benazir Bhutto holds the cards to the future of Pakistan.

Bhutto's call on November 13 for President Pervez Musharraf to step down, not only as army chief but as head of state, "since he has lost the confidence of the people of Pakistan", came as a political thunderbolt. She was the only major Opposition leader who had steadfastly refused to join the chorus of voices calling for Musharraf to go, her reluctance causing serious resentment in the Opposition and gleeful satisfaction within the Government. Her categorical call, which seemed to preclude any possibility of working under the President, galvanised her own Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) and the frayed political opposition, both of which had been unsure of her intentions towards the General till then. And it was the surest indication that a potential US-backed "deal" between the two had fallen through.

Musharraf's only hope of avoiding an all-out confrontation with an increasingly restive citizenry was pinned on the



BENAZIR'S GAMEPLAN

By calling for the General's resignation, she has reinvented herself as frontline opposition to the military strong

protests, against his suspension of the Constitution, losing momentum because of the lack of involvement of organised political parties. After an initially lukewarm reaction to the imposition of martial rule, Bhutto turned up the political temperature with her announcement of a "long march", in protest, from Lahore to Islamabad through parts of Punjab. Her subsequent detention by the Government added fuel to fire. Her party's role in the protests and attempts to unite the Opposition should be Musharraf's worst nightmare. Sufficient chaos on the streets and large-scale boycott of the elections, to be held in January, could force the army to act against its leader. Pakistan is in for difficult days.

But if Musharraf has stumbled badly after eight years of relative smooth sail, the one person who has come up trumps is "the daughter of the East". Bhutto's return from the polit-

ical wilderness and her re-invention as frontline opposition to the military strongman mark a transformation few would have believed possible even a month ago. When she returned home on October 18 after eight years of self-imposed exile, Bhutto was decried for having sold her soul to the devil by compromising with a military dictator in return for personal gain. She had fled the country in early 1999—before Musharraf took over in a coup, as part of an understanding with her rival Nawaz Sharif's government—to escape serious corruption cases. Since the cases could not be heard in absentia, they continued to linger without a conclusion. But under Musharraf, the Government's National Accountability Bureau—which estimated at one time that Bhutto and her husband Asif Zardari had siphoned off up to \$1.5 billion (Rs 6,000 crore) through corrupt means—pursued cases against